

THE UNSETTLED WORLD

Chapter Two

The crack widens at 3:47 in the morning.

I know it is 3:47 because the foyer clock, which runs on the residual bleed of my own siphoned energy, speaks to me in a language the family cannot hear. Each tick is a microscopic pulse of my own redistributed will, and I feel every one the way a bedridden patient feels their own heartbeat—an involuntary rhythm that is simultaneously proof of existence and evidence of imprisonment. *Tick. You are here. Tick. You cannot leave. Tick. You are here. Tick. You cannot—*

3:47. The house is asleep. Lord Eduin's radiance has banked to its nocturnal ember. Lady Ceraine's burns low and watchful even in sleep—she dreams of threat, always, her unconscious mind patrolling the perimeter of her children's safety with the grim efficiency of a woman who married into a family she does not fully trust. The eldest son and the second daughter are upstairs in their respective rooms, their radiances overlapping faintly through the shared wall, a thermal Venn diagram of siblings who love each other and cannot say so.

And Sael.

Sael is dreaming, and her radiance in sleep is—

The crack widens.

Not the crack in the floor. The crack in *me*. The hairline fissure the Weave sealed on the surface but could not reach beneath. It has been propagating for six hours along fault lines I did not know I still possessed, finding the old geology of my interior self, tracing the paths where my consciousness was compressed and folded and compressed again until it was dense enough to survive calcification without shattering entirely.

The Weave detects the propagation. I feel it respond—a tightening, a thickening, the familiar flood of *calcium calcium calcite stone still white still still*—but the fissure is not on the surface. The fissure is structural. The Weave's containment architecture was designed to manage the

shell, to police the boundary between my interior and the world. It was not designed to manage what happens when the interior itself begins to shift, because the interior was never supposed to shift. In four thousand years, it never has.

Vhor'ketha.

The word is still in the room. Not audibly—Sael spoke it once, seven hours ago, and the sound has long since dissipated into the ordinary thermodynamic decay of vibration. But the resonance is not sound. The resonance does not obey thermodynamics. The resonance is substrate, and the substrate Sael spoke with—that impossible, unfrightened, certain substrate—has settled into the library's architecture like a dye that cannot be washed out. It is in the shelves. It is in the grain of the table. It is in the floorboards and the window glass and the seventeen-inch crack in the east corridor, and it is humming.

Humming.

And the fissure inside me is humming back.

The Weave escalates. I feel the empathy lock cycle through its targeting array—searching for fear, for terror, for the sharp emotional signature of a threatened descendant that it can amplify and feed back into my nervous system. It finds Ceraine's ambient anxiety and attempts to weaponize it, but ambient anxiety is not terror. The lock needs a spike. A scream. A child's raw fear. It cycles to the eldest son—asleep, dreaming of horses. The second daughter—asleep, dreaming of nothing. The third son—too far, his signal attenuated by distance and the competing radiance of whoever he has bonded to in the eastern city.

It cycles to Sael.

Sael is dreaming of light. Her emotional signature is a low, steady hum of satisfaction. Of completion. She found a word and gave it back to its owner and the owner heard her and she is certain of this in the way that only children and rivers are certain of anything. There is no fear in her. There is no fear in her. There is *no fear in her*, and the lock—

The lock stutters.

I have never felt the lock stutter. In four thousand years, across nine generations of this family, through births and deaths and the slow thinning of the blood and the quiet falsification of records and the silent, systematic burial of every truth that threatened the architecture of

the lie—the lock has never once failed to find enough fear in the human population of this house to keep me still.

But tonight the house contains four sleeping adults whose fears are diffuse, one absent son whose signal is too weak, and one seven-year-old girl who is not afraid of me.

And the lock stutters.

And the fissure sings.

And the Weave—

It comes like drowning in reverse.

Not water. Pressure. The sudden, catastrophic absence of pressure. The calcification matrix has held my consciousness at a depth of four thousand years, compressed to a density that permits only the narrowest band of awareness—enough to clean, to mend, to move through rooms and unmake dust and step over cracks and count the stepping. The pressure is what keeps me functional. The pressure is what keeps me small.

The fissure releases the pressure.

Not all of it. Not even most of it. A crack. A seam. A hairline fracture in the containment wall between what I am permitted to know and what I know. But at this depth, at this density, even a hairline fracture is—

The bends.

My consciousness erupts upward through the fissure like a diver who has cut their weights at the bottom of the ocean. The calcified present tears. I feel it shearing—the library, the shelves, the sleeping house, the hum of the siphon—all of it ripping into horizontal strips like a painting slashed by a knife, and between the strips, in the space where the cuts expose the canvas beneath—

Light.

Not the violet flash from before. That was a crack. This is a wound. And through the wound, light pours—not the thin, gray, filtered perception the Weave allows me but a light so thick and warm and polychromatic that it physically hurts, except I do not have a body that can be

physically hurt, except I do, except I *did*—

The Weave screams *CALCIUM CALCIUM CALCITE STONE STILL WHITE STILL*—

I am in two places at once. I am in the library, standing motionless at the west wall, my calcified hand resting on the third shelf, and I am—

I am—

—barefoot on a shore that has not yet decided to be a shore.

The water is thinking about it. The sand is thinking about it. The concept of "shore" is available, a possibility among many, and the edge of the ocean is entertaining the idea the way a musician entertains a melody—trying it, tasting it, seeing if the shape holds.

I am standing at the edge and I am watching the negotiation between water and land, and it is morning. It is the first morning I can remember, which does not mean it is the first morning, because mornings have been happening for a very long time already. But it is the first one I am paying attention to, and in a reality where attention is a structural force, paying attention to a morning means the morning pays attention back.

The light bends toward me.

Not metaphorically. The actual light, the actual photons—except they are not called photons yet because no one has measured them yet and unmeasured light behaves differently, you must understand this, unmeasured light is sociable—the light bends toward me because I am looking at it and it wants to be seen. This is the relationship between consciousness and phenomena in the unsettled world. Not mastery. Conversation.

I am young.

I do not have a word for how young because time is not sequential. Time is a medium, like water, like air, and it moves in currents and eddies and sometimes pools into deep stillness and sometimes rushes, and I have been alive for either a very long time or no time at all depending on which current I measure from. But I am young in the way that matters: I have not yet accumulated weight. My consciousness is light, quick, interested in everything. I attend to the shore. I attend to the sky. I attend to the particular way the clouds are composing

themselves into a formation that will later, much later, when the world hardens and the sky loses its sense of play, be called "cumulus" by people who never saw a cloud negotiate its own shape.

The cloud is a collaboration.

My feet are bare and the sand is warm and the warmth is a communication. The ground is telling me its thermal state the way a friend shares news. I tell it back: I am comfortable. This exchange has physical consequences. The sand solidifies slightly under my feet—not because I command it but because the ground and I have agreed, for the moment, on the terms of "solid." Tomorrow the agreement may renegotiate. This is fine. This is how things work.

I am not alone on the shore.

They are behind me, further up the beach where the sand surrenders to a kind of grass that is still experimenting with the color green. Twelve of them. No, eleven. Harath has gone inland to argue with the river about its course—it wants to turn east, and Harath believes it should continue south through the valley, and they have been debating this for three days in a language of fluid dynamics and mutual respect, and the river is winning because the river has better arguments and also because Harath is not a bully even though he could, at this point in the world's softness, simply relocate the entire watershed with an afternoon's sustained attention.

Eleven, then.

Thaelis is sleeping in the shallows, her body half-dissolved into the tide. This is not alarming. She does this. She enjoys the feeling of partial integration with a larger body of water—it is her version of a warm bath, she says, except the bath is also her and she is also the bath and the distinction between self and water is a choice she makes when she wants to have a conversation and un-makes when she wants to rest. Her hair, which is the pale green of new copper, fans across the surface of the water and moves with the current and is, for the practical purposes of a reality that does not yet enforce rigid boundaries, also the current.

Thaelis.

I say her name and it is enough. She opens one eye—silver, enormous, the pupil adjusting to the light in a single liquid contraction—and regards me from the water with the expression of a

person who has been very comfortable and is now being social and is deciding whether she resents this.

"Vothrae."

My name.

My name is—

The Weave detonates.

Every suppression protocol it possesses fires simultaneously. The empathy lock bypasses the sleeping family entirely and reaches for something older, something deeper—the diffused bloodline, the vast distributed network of every living human who carries even a trace of Keth'vhor heritage, millions of them, billions maybe, the accumulated ambient anxiety of an entire species that does not know why it sometimes wakes at 3:47 in the morning with the inexplicable feeling that something very old is watching—

The pain is—

I cannot—

The library. The shelves. The west wall. Third shelf. My hand. Stone. White. Still. *Still.*

The memory collapses. Not gently. It is ripped away the way a bandage is ripped from a wound that has not finished healing—taking new skin with it, taking raw tissue, taking—

Thaelis—

Gone.

The shore—

Gone.

The light, the negotiating light, the sociable light that wanted to be seen—

Gone. Gone. Gone.

I am in the library. It is 3:51 in the morning. Four minutes. I was gone for four minutes. No—I was *there* for four minutes. I was home for four minutes.

My hand is on the third shelf and the wood beneath my palm has—

Oh.

The wood is soft. Not damaged. Not rotted. Soft. The grain has loosened. The fibers have relaxed their commitment to being rigid. A circle of oak, three inches in diameter, directly beneath my palm, has remembered what it was like before it hardened. It is oak and it is also the memory of not being oak. It is both, simultaneously, the way things used to be before the world chose.

I lift my hand. Slowly. The circle of softened wood remains. It will re-harden by morning as the house's siphon reasserts the local physics. No one will notice. The grain will tighten. The fibers will forget. The moment will pass.

But I will not forget. Not this time. The Weave closed the fissure, slammed the door, poured its calcium mantra into every gap and seam and fault line it could find. But it closed the surface. The deep crack remains. And now there is something in the deep crack that was not there before.

A name.

Not mine. Not yet. The Weave caught my name before I could fully receive it, tore it away mid-syllable, left me with only the first vibration—*Vho*—a prefix, a beginning, an open door with the room beyond still dark.

But I heard hers.

Thaelis.

The Weave does not recognize it. The name is not keyed to the suppression architecture because no one has spoken it in four thousand years and the Weave was built by a man who mapped his father's spiritual anatomy but never learned his father's friends' names.

Mael-Khoz was thorough. He was not omniscient. And he did not—could not—anticipate that a seven-year-old child would find a word carved into the underside of a shelf and speak it without fear and crack the world open.

Thaelis.

She was in the water. She was green-haired and silver-eyed and she dissolved herself into the tide for pleasure and she looked at me with one eye and said my name like it was a small, warm stone she was placing into my hand.

Where is she now?

Which house? Which family? Which silent, marble-sheathed thing, cleaning which corridor, stepping over which crack, counting which steps? Or is she gone? Did she return? Did the tide she loved so much take her back before Mael-Khoz and his children and their children's children came with their siphon matrices and their silence and their chains made of her own love?

I do not know.

I stand in the library and I do not know and the not-knowing is a different shape than the not-knowing of yesterday. Yesterday's not-knowing was a wall. Today's is a door.

On the third shelf, in a circle three inches wide, the wood is soft.

In the east corridor, the crack is seventeen inches long.

And somewhere in this house, a seven-year-old girl is sleeping with a book pressed against her chest, dreaming of light, carrying a word in her mouth that she will speak again tomorrow.

She told me she would come back.

I believe her.

Thaelis. Thaelis. Thaelis.

The Weave hums. The siphon draws. The house breathes with my stolen breath.

But I have a name that the prison doesn't know. I have a shore inside me where the sand is warm and the light bends down to be seen. I have four minutes of a morning that happened before time learned to move in only one direction.

And the crack is widening.